



## WESTERN INTERVENTION ... CHAOS AND ANARCHY !



Learning Space



# NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS ... DISCUSSION

3<sup>rd</sup> MAY, 2019



3

## Predictable chaos in Libya

The Iraqi-Libyan species of intervention, with UN approval but under the West's watch, is a post Cold-War phenomenon



KRISHNAN SRINIVASAN

General Khalifa Haftar, head of the Libyan National Army, is advancing on the capital Tripoli, having taken control of the east of the country including most of the oilfields. Gen. Haftar had helped Muammar Qaddafi seize power in 1969 before going into exile in the U.S. in the 1980s, but returned to Libya in 2001 to join in Qaddafi's overthrow. He now casts himself as a conservative Salafist opposing Islamists and the Muslim Brothers, and has the backing – for their individual reasons – of Egypt, Saudi Arabia and some West Asian states, apart from Russia (openly) and France (covertly).

### Libya's descent

The United Nations recognised Tripoli's administration is called the Government of National Accord, but is anything but that, being dependent on a motley of warlords, militant or moderate Islamists, secessionists and monarchists, all split on regional and ethnic lines. Even before Gen. Haftar launched his offensive, West Libya was replete with inter-militia battles and kidnappings. The Tripoli government commands no security forces, public administration scarcely exists, water, petrol and power shortages abound, and few banks operate. Thousands are

fleeing towards Tunisia, and 180 people have been killed so far in the recent fighting.

The rule of the gun prevails in Libya ever since western forces overthrew Qaddafi. The oil-rich country, now a departure point for thousands of migrants travelling to Europe, once had one of Africa's highest standards of living, free health care and education, with high female literacy and percentage of women in the workplace. Its inland waterway to green the eastern desert was called the world's largest irrigation project. But after the western armed intervention supported by some Arab sheikhdoms, a perceptive commentator noted, "Nothing was certain, least of all what kind of country Libya would now become."

The revolt against Qaddafi began in Benghazi, and western intervention was legitimised by the fig leaf of a UN Security Council resolution calling for a ceasefire, a no-fly zone and protection of civilians, on which there were five abstentions which included India, Russia and China. Qaddafi accepted the resolution. Shortly thereafter, France, the U.K. and the U.S. attacked Qaddafi's forces and NATO assumed responsibility for regime change at the same moment that an African Union mediation mission was en route to Libya.

The Libyan tragedy, like those in Iraq, Syria and Yemen, and most probably to ensue in Afghanistan, illustrates wider issues at play. Iraq, warring militias after the Second Gulf War empowered jihadists, made Iraq ungovernable, U.S. withdrawal inevitable, and led to the Islamisation of the nation.



No lessons were learned, causing former U.S. President Barack Obama to confess that his worst mistake was a failure to prepare for the aftermath of western intervention following Qaddafi's overthrow. Western wishful thinking persists in the belief that Libya could arrive at a path to democracy that revives the country's collapsed institutions, rather than falling under military rule.

### Post Cold-War phenomenon

In 1965 and 1981, the UN adopted declarations on the inadmissibility of intervention in the domestic affairs of states, and until the 1990s the UN was the custodian of state sovereignty. The Iraqi-Libyan species of intervention, professedly with UN approval but actually under western control, is a post Cold-War phenomenon, the motivation being to implant liberal democracy in institutions and human rights, along with security concerns, usually thinly justified by 9/11 and lately the Islamic State. Exogenous state-building and a peripheral role for local leaders characterise this innovation in international relations. The spectre of failed states became a major concern, leading to the imposition of a neo-liberal agenda in the guise of human

rights protection.

The ambiguous legal justification for interventions not specifically authorised by the UN, such as the creation of safe havens in Iraq, established a pattern despite negative precedents that showed that attempting nation-building in societies divided by ethnic, factional, ideological and religious lines is beyond the capacity of any minority group of UN members, let alone of one super-power. None of the interventions could have taken place without the projection of U.S. power or its indirect underwriting.

Two factors paved the way for these neo-protectorates: activists with rights-based agendas joined the political mainstream, and western outrage to repressed suffering. Activists united with foreign policy establishments, and third world disorder presented opportunities for sly expansion of mandates into new operating areas. Added to these was post 1990 revisionism towards state sovereignty and permissive new to humanitarian interventions. Relativism towards sovereignty was anathema to post-colonial independent states, especially when western interventions were selective and political in nature, and the victims of intervention lacked the power to oppose.

Western nations came to contemplate, albeit fitfully and inconsistently, neutralising a number of sovereign states in the third world that were illiberal, war-torn or internally weak, as potential threats to international peace. But this essentially political project was pre-

sented as a high-minded enterprise with altruistic motivations, similar to the post-war occupations of Germany and Japan.

There were many reasons for the failure of state-building in the new protectorates. The new elites were never very different or more liberal than those disposed. Organised criminality was invigorated by opportunities created by the absence of proper law enforcement due to outsiders not understanding the consequences of their policies. This was because the interveners were more concerned with checking the power of institutions rather than building them, and to appease domestic opinion back home, concentrated on exit strategies and political markers such as holding elections. If the outcome was doubtful even in Kosovo in Europe, the challenge of transforming political and social cultures in the world beyond Europe, where there is no economic pull factor and traditions have little in common with western liberalism, was obviously far more formidable.

As for humanitarian arguments and the Responsibility to Protect doctrine, such reasoning is malleable enough to be appropriated by Russia in Georgia and Ukraine. Whether in Libya or elsewhere, expeditionary interventions to implant human rights and democracy have a certain heuristic value in understanding the illusions of western hegemony which rose to prominence in our times and sought to mould the third world in its image.

Krishnan Srinivasan is a former Foreign Secretary

## UPSC CSE – GS II

### GS II ... International Relations

Effect of policies and politics of developed and developing countries on India's interests, Indian diaspora.

## IMPORTANT QUESTION

### ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

Exogenous efforts of state-building and a peripheral role for local leaders could not ensure democratic transition after the intervention by the foreign powers. Discuss.



### 3 Predictable chaos in Libya

The Iraqi-Libyan species of intervention, with UN 'approval' but under the West's watch, is a post Cold-War phenomenon

General Khalifa Haftar, head of the Libyan National Army, is advancing on the capital Tripoli, having taken control of the east of the country including most of the oilfields. Gen. Haftar had helped Muammar Qaddafi seize power in 1969 before going into exile in the U.S. in the 1980s, but returned to Libya in 2011 to join in Qaddafi's overthrow. He now casts himself as a conservative Salafist opposing Islamists and the Muslim Brothers, and has the backing — for their individual reasons — of Egypt, Saudi Arabia and some West Asian states, apart from Russia (openly) and France (covertly).

Libya's descent

The United Nations recognised Tripoli's administration is called the Government of National Accord, but is anything but that, being dependent on a motley of warlords, militant or moderate Islamists, secessionists and monarchists, all split on regional and ethnic lines. Even before Gen. Haftar launched his offensive, West Libya was replete with inter-militia battles and kidnappings. The Tripoli government commands no security forces, public administration scarcely exists, water, petrol and power shortages abound, and few banks operate. Thousands are fleeing towards Tunisia, and 180 people have been killed so far in the recent fighting. The rule of the gun prevails in Libya ever since western forces overthrew Qaddafi. The oil-rich country, now a departure point for thousands of migrants travelling to Europe, once had one of Africa's highest standards of living, free health care and education, with high female literacy and percentage of women in the workplace. Its inland waterway to green the eastern desert was called the world's largest irrigation project. But after the western armed intervention supported by some Arab sheikhdoms, a perceptive commentator noted, "Nothing was certain, least of all what kind of country Libya would now become."

...Contd.





### 3 Predictable chaos in Libya

The revolt against Qaddafi began in Benghazi, and western intervention was legitimised by the fig leaf of a UN Security Council resolution calling for a ceasefire, a no-fly zone and protection of civilians, on which there were five abstentions which included India, Russia and China. Qaddafi accepted the resolution. Shortly thereafter, France, the U.K. and the U.S. attacked Qaddafi's forces and NATO assumed responsibility for regime change at the same moment that an African Union mediation mission was en route to Libya.

The Libyan tragedy, like those in Iraq, Syria and Yemen, and most probably to ensue in Afghanistan, illustrates wider issues at play. Iraqi warring militias after the Second Gulf War empowered jihadists, made Iraq ungovernable, U.S. withdrawal inevitable, and led to the Balkanisation of the nation. No lessons were learned, causing former U.S. President Barack Obama to confess that his worst mistake was a failure to prepare for the aftermath of western intervention following Qaddafi's overthrow. Western wishful thinking persists in the belief that Libya could arrive at a path to democracy that revives the country's collapsed institutions, rather than falling under military rule.

Post Cold-War phenomenon

In 1965 and 1981, the UN adopted declarations on the inadmissibility of intervention in the domestic affairs of states, and until the 1990s the UN was the custodian of state sovereignty. The Iraqi-Libyan species of intervention, professedly with UN approval but actually under western control, is a post Cold-War phenomenon, the motivation being to implant liberal democratic institutions and human rights, along with security concerns, usually thinly justified by 9/11 and lately the Islamic State. Exogenous state-building and a peripheral role for local leaders characterise this innovation in international relations. The spectre of failed states became a major concern, leading to the imposition of a neo-liberal agenda in the guise of human rights protection.



### 3 Predictable chaos in Libya

The ambiguous legal justification for interventions not specifically authorised by the UN, such as the creation of safe havens in Iraq, established a pattern despite negative precedents that showed that attempting nation-building in societies divided by ethnic, factional, ideological and religious lines is beyond the capacity of any minority group of UN members, let alone of one super-power. None of the interventions could have taken place without the projection of U.S. power or its indirect underwriting.

Two factors paved the way for these neo-protectorates; activists with rights-based agendas joined the political mainstream, and western outrage to televised suffering. Activists united with foreign policy establishments, and third world disorder presented opportunities for sly expansion of mandates into new operating areas. Added to these was post-1990 revisionism towards state sovereignty and permissiveness to humanitarian interventions. Relativism towards sovereignty was anathema to post-colonial independent states, especially when western interventions were selective and political in nature, and the victims of intervention lacked the power to oppose.

Western nations came to contemplate, albeit fitfully and inconsistently, neutralising a number of sovereign states in the third world that were illiberal, war-torn or internally weak, as potential threats to international peace. But this essentially political project was presented as a high-minded enterprise with altruistic motivations, similar to the post-war occupations of Germany and Japan.

There were many reasons for the failure of state-building in the new protectorates. The new elites were never very different or more liberal than those deposed. Organised criminality was invigorated by opportunities created by the absence of proper law enforcement due to outsiders not understanding the consequences of their policies.



### 3 Predictable chaos in Libya

This was because the interveners were more concerned with checking the power of institutions rather than building them, and to appease domestic opinion back home, concentrated on exit strategies and political markers such as holding elections. If the outcome was doubtful even in Kosovo in Europe, the challenge of transforming political and social cultures in the world beyond Europe, where there is no economic pull factor and traditions have little in common with western liberalism, was obviously far more formidable.

As for humanitarian arguments and the Responsibility to Protect doctrine, such reasoning is malleable enough to be appropriated by Russia in Georgia and Ukraine. Whether in Libya or elsewhere, expeditionary interventions to implant human rights and democracy have a certain heuristic value in understanding the illusions of western hegemony which rose to prominence in our times and sought to mould the third world in its image.

Krishnan Srinivasan is a former Foreign Secretary



# DICTATORSHIP TO ANARCHY ... CASE OF LIBYA!



- Arab Spring protests of 2011 led to a civil war, foreign military intervention and the ousting and death of Muammar Gaddafi.
- War destroyed the Libyan state and institutions.
- It left the country in the hands of competing militias.
- It is yet to recover from the anarchy (absence of legitimate Government/lawlessness) triggered by the intervention.
- The country has the largest oil reserves of any African country.
- Now it is into chaos.





## SEE THE PLIGHT OF LIBYA!



France, the U.K. and the U.S. attacked Qaddafi's forces and NATO assumed responsibility for regime change.

**1** The oil-rich country, once had one of Africa's highest standards of living, with free health care and education, with high female literacy and percentage of women in the workplace.

**2** The inland waterway project to green the eastern desert was called the world's largest irrigation project.



# INTERVENING IN THE STATE SOVEREIGNTY ... POST COLD-WAR PHENOMENON!



- 1 In 1965 and 1981, the UN adopted declarations on the inadmissibility of intervention in the domestic affairs of states.

- 2 Until the 1990s, the UN was the custodian of state sovereignty.

- 3 The Iraqi-Libyan interventions under the western powers control, is a post Cold-War phenomenon. UN was the silent spectator and in some cases Western Powers enjoyed tacit support of UN

- 4 The motivation is to implant liberal democratic institutions and human rights, along with security concerns.

*Exogenous efforts of state-building and a peripheral role for local leaders characterise this innovation in international relations.*



# WHAT WENT WRONG WITH THE EFFORTS OF THE WESTERN POWERS?



- The new elites were never different or more liberal than those deposed.
- Organised criminality was invigorated by the opportunities created by the absence of proper law enforcement mechanisms.
- They concentrated on checking the power of institutions rather than building them.
- They concentrated on exit strategies.
- There is no economic pull factor.
- Traditions and western liberalism do not go together.
- The ethos of dictatorship are in-built.



*Attempts in nation-building in societies divided by ethnic, factional, ideological and religious lines is beyond the capacity of any minority group of UN Members.*



WE EXPRESS OUR  
SINCERE THANKS  
FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

Presented by



Learning Space

For Suggestions:

[suggestions@learningspace.in](mailto:suggestions@learningspace.in)

To Contact us:

[info@learningspace.in](mailto:info@learningspace.in)

**OUR TEAM**

G. V. Rao  
K. Srikanth  
D. Sunil Kumar  
L. V. Krishna  
Y. Deepthi

Amrita Naidu  
M. Binukrishna  
G. Ravi Babu  
D. Joji  
K. Victor Babu

Visit us at:

[www.learningspacedigital.com](http://www.learningspacedigital.com)

0 8 6 6 -2 4 4 4 4 7 2  
0 9 8 4 9 9 4 2 2 9 9